



sports MOHALI TEST

CRICKET CAULDRON

Following the annihilation of the world champions at Mohali, India must untangle a new dilemma: how to handle the return of Anil Kumble into the perfect 11 who played the "perfect Test"

■ By Sharda Ugra in Mohali

A few days after Ricky Ponting and Co. landed in India, news about their not-so-hostile welcome from the Rajasthan Cricket Association (RCA) academy filtered out. Along with the culture and the camel rides, 10 specialised practice pitches had been prepared, to simulate different kinds of spinning beasts the Aussies could expect in the four-Test series against India.

When an Indian player heard about the pitches, he offered a wry response, "They've got the turners, but they don't have Kumble and Harbhajan bowling to them, do they?" Or even, going by evidence of Mohali, any old Mishraji, Sharmaji or Khan-sahib.

After Mohali, India is somewhat bewildered:

is this the world's No.1 team or some other bouncer-sized blokes wearing stolen headgear?

After Mohali, the pre-series face-off between India's batting and Australia's bowling has been inverted, partly you suspect out of kindness to what Australia refer to as its 'attack'.

After Mohali, it looks as if the Border-Gavaskar Trophy will be moving residences soon. After all, didn't India play what M.S. Dhoni called a "perfect match" spanking Australia by 320 runs, their heaviest margin of defeat this century?

It is all true. But in the bubble of euphoria and hubris, it is useful to remember that while the Aussies have been crushed, they have not been crushed conclusively. That result is still two weeks away and for it to come about, India will have to be perfect, at least one more time.

All things considered though, something